My first journal entry is about problem framing.
At the beginning, our question was quite broad: how might we help people make friends when they enter a new environment? We initially thought the main problem was that newcomers could not find suitable social activities. However, after discussing different experiences, we realized that finding an event was only one part of the problem. People might still feel uncomfortable joining an existing group, starting a conversation, or contacting someone again after the first meeting.
My second entry focuses on research planning.
We prepared interviews about how residents interact in shared accommodation and community spaces. Instead of immediately asking people what kind of app they wanted, we asked about their actual experiences. For example, we asked where conversations normally happen, what makes them easier, what barriers people experience, and what helps them maintain a new connection.
The third entry is about the interviews.
The interviews showed that many social interactions begin naturally in shared spaces, such as kitchens, lifts, common rooms and accommodation events. Shared interests and seeing the same people regularly can make interaction easier. However, language confidence, busy schedules, established friendship groups and fear of awkwardness can prevent people from participating.
An important insight was that quiet people are not necessarily unwilling to socialize. They may simply need more time, a clear reason to speak, or a lower-pressure environment.
In the fourth entry, we synthesized these findings.
We used affinity mapping to organize the interview data into themes. This included difficulty entering an existing group, different levels of social comfort, gradual motivation, the importance of shared spaces, and common interests as a bridge.
From these themes, we developed several design principles. The service should support smaller groups, provide a shared activity, allow different levels of participation, and help people maintain a connection after their first meeting.
My fifth entry covers our storyboard and ethical considerations.
We created a storyboard showing a newcomer selecting interests, joining a small local circle, attending an activity and continuing the relationship afterwards. The storyboard helped us understand FriendZone as a complete user journey rather than just a collection of app features.
We also considered privacy, consent, safety and inclusion. We realized that rewards and tracking could create pressure, particularly because our users may already feel socially vulnerable.
The sixth entry is about prototype development.
Our first prototype included interest selection, recommended circles, group chat, conversation

prompts and rewards. Later iterations added optional profiles, improved matching, search, circle creation and an in-person mode.

However, this also created a problem. As we continued adding features, FriendZone started to look like another general social networking platform. I learned that adding more functions does not necessarily make the central idea stronger.

The seventh entry focuses on conversation prompts.

Based on the interview findings, we identified the conversation prompt as one of our strongest interactions. The prompt gives users a reason to start speaking, especially when they do not know what to say.

Our idea was that the phone could help prepare people for interaction, but it should not dominate the actual meeting. Once the conversation begins, users should be encouraged to put their phones down and focus on face-to-face communication.

The eighth entry is about the feedback we received during the studio presentation.

We were asked why someone would use FriendZone instead of Facebook Events, Eventbrite or another existing meetup service. We realized that small groups alone were not enough to make the concept distinctive.

The feedback encouraged us to narrow our target audience, focus on one or two important interactions, and connect every feature to research evidence. We therefore stopped expanding the application and researched loneliness, phone use, gamification and face-to-face interaction in more depth.

My final entry covers evaluation and redesign.

We tested the prototype with four participants using several tasks and the System Usability Scale. The average SUS score was 63.1, but individual scores ranged from 20 to 90, so the usability experience was inconsistent.

The conversation prompts received the most positive feedback. Participants felt that prompts could help quieter users break the ice. However, the NFC workflow, timer and leaderboard were confusing for some participants.

The leaderboard also created concerns about competition, privacy and social pressure. Participants questioned what information was being recorded, who could see it, and whether the amount of time spent together really represented the quality of a friendship.

Based on these findings, our current direction is to keep the conversation prompts and the phone-down concept but move away from public ranking. Instead of a leaderboard, we are considering a friend relationship map. This would visualize connections and possible friendship groups without ranking users against each other.

Overall, the main thing I learned is that our project became stronger when we stopped trying to solve every part of loneliness and focused on a specific moment: helping someone move from wanting social connection to having a comfortable, meaningful face-to-face conversation.